

شاعر، آواز اور قوالی

URDU FOR POETRY LOVERS

VOLUME 8 • POETS, VOICES & QAWWALI

*recognise the poet • hear the tradition • enter the gathering
eight signature voices • twelve qawwali encounters • a listening apprenticeship*

Prepared for

Mahesh Premachandra

From Poems to Poetic Personalities

Volume 7 taught you to compare poems across themes. Volume 8 reverses the lens: it asks how one enduring temperament transforms every theme it touches. You will learn to recognise Meer's wounded simplicity, Ghalib's intellectual theatre, Momin's intimacy, Dagħ's spoken elegance, Zafar's exile, Iqbal's ascent, Hasrat's double fidelity to love and freedom, and Faiz's widening of the beloved into history.

Then the room changes • The second half moves from the solitary page to qawwali: poetry organised by voice, response, repetition, breath, rhythm and collective attention.

Eight poet portraits • Biography is kept brief; signature language, syntax, imagery and emotional movement receive priority.

A recognition method • Identify a voice from its favourite tensions rather than from a memorised date.

Thirty-six qawwali words • Learn the spiritual and performance vocabulary that ordinary glossaries flatten.

Twelve encounters • Read short traditional or public-domain passages through sound, meaning and performance.

A listening notebook • Train your ear to distinguish text, improvisation, refrain, inserted verse and audience response.

The Seven-Fingerprint Poet Method

- 1 • **Address** • Does the poet speak to the beloved, self, God, city, nation, reader—or several at once?
- 2 • **Favourite hinge** • Notice lekin, goya, warna, phir, hi, bhi and kya: argument often lives in tiny words.
- 3 • **Image climate** • Garden, dust, cage, mirror, road, dawn and chain acquire different pressure in different poets.
- 4 • **Scale** • Does a sher remain intimate, leap into metaphysics, or widen toward history?
- 5 • **Emotional posture** • Complaint, irony, surrender, invitation, exhortation and witness are distinct stances.
- 6 • **Sentence music** • Short spoken clauses feel unlike Persianised conceptual architecture; hear before classifying.
- 7 • **Productive contradiction** • A durable poetic voice repeatedly inhabits one impossible tension without resolving it.

Warning • Recognition is probabilistic, not a parlour game. Many poets share inherited images; attribution requires textual evidence beyond mood alone.

Eight Voices at a Glance

POET	SIGNATURE PRESSURE	LISTEN FOR
Meer Taqi Meer 1723-1810	the inner weather of ruin	saadgi • dard • dil • khaak
Mirza Ghalib 1797-1869	metaphysical wit and impossible questions	hasti • khayaal • imkaan • hairat
Momin Khan Momin 1800-1852	intimacy, concealment and presence	tum • goya • paas • raaz
Dagh Dehlvi 1831-1905	urbane speech and elegant complaint	zabaan • ada • shikwa • mulaaqaat
Bahadur Shah Zafar 1775-1862	exile, impermanence and late sorrow	vatan • qafas • umr • nishaan
Allama Iqbal 1877-1938	selfhood, ascent and awakening	khudi • parwaaz • shaheen • amal
Hasrat Mohani 1875-1951	romance joined to freedom	ishq • inquilaab • yaad • siyasat
Faiz Ahmed Faiz 1911-1984	private love widened into public conscience	subh • zanjeer • mehboob • insaaf

Portrait 01 • Meer Taqi Meer

میر تقی میر

1723–1810 • the inner weather of ruin

Signature voice • Simple words carry accumulated devastation; the city, heart and self often collapse into one another.

Recognition cluster • saadgi • dard • dil • khaak

A signature sher

پتا پتا بوٹا بوٹا حال ہمارا جانے ہے
جانے نہ جانے گل ہی نہ جانے باغ تو سارا جانے ہے

patta patta boota boota haal hamaara jaane hai / jaane na jaane gul hi na jaane, baagh to saara jaane hai

Working sense • Every leaf and plant knows my condition; only the rose may not, though the whole garden does.

Four-pass portrait

Speech • Which word makes this sound like this poet rather than a generic lover?

Tension • Name the contradiction the sher refuses to solve.

Scale • Where does the poem move—from body to world, intimacy to history, or wit to metaphysics?

Imitation • Write a new two-line thought using the same emotional movement but different images.

Listening cue • Hear three reciters or singers. Record what each does with pause, speed and the final pressure word.

Portrait 02 • Mirza Ghalib

مرزا غالب

1797–1869 • metaphysical wit and impossible questions

Signature voice • A statement turns against itself. Grammar, theology and comedy meet inside a voice that doubts even its own doubt.

Recognition cluster • hasti • khayaal • imkaan • hairat

A signature sher

نہ تھا کچھ تو خدا تھا کچھ نہ ہوتا تو خدا ہوتا
ڈبویا مجھ کو ہونے نے نہ ہوتا میں تو کیا ہوتا

na tha kuchh to khuda tha, kuchh na hota to khuda hota / duboya mujh ko hone ne, na hota main to kya hota

Working sense • When nothing existed, God was; existence drowned me—had I not existed, what would I have been?

Four-pass portrait

Speech • Which word makes this sound like this poet rather than a generic lover?

Tension • Name the contradiction the sher refuses to solve.

Scale • Where does the poem move—from body to world, intimacy to history, or wit to metaphysics?

Imitation • Write a new two-line thought using the same emotional movement but different images.

Listening cue • Hear three reciters or singers. Record what each does with pause, speed and the final pressure word.

Portrait 03 • Momin Khan Momin

مومن خاں مومن

1800–1852 • intimacy, concealment and presence

Signature voice • His finest couplets can feel conversational, but pronouns and pauses produce exquisite emotional uncertainty.

Recognition cluster • tum • goya • paas • raaz

A signature sher

تم میرے پاس ہوتے ہو گویا

جب کوئی دوسرا نہیں ہوتا

tum mere paas hote ho goya / jab koi doosra nahin hota

Working sense • It is as though you are beside me whenever no one else is present.

Four-pass portrait

Speech • Which word makes this sound like this poet rather than a generic lover?

Tension • Name the contradiction the sher refuses to solve.

Scale • Where does the poem move—from body to world, intimacy to history, or wit to metaphysics?

Imitation • Write a new two-line thought using the same emotional movement but different images.

Listening cue • Hear three reciters or singers. Record what each does with pause, speed and the final pressure word.

Portrait 04 • Daghlvi

داغ دہلوی

1831–1905 • urbane speech and elegant complaint

Signature voice • Daghl makes polished poetry sound spoken. Social finesse, flirtation and wounded pride share the same breath.

Recognition cluster • zabaan • ada • shikwa • mulaaqaat

A signature sher

غضب کیا ترے وعدے پہ اعتبار کیا
تمام رات قیامت کا انتظار کیا

ghazab kiya tere vaade pe aitbaar kiya / tamaam raat qayaamat ka intezaar kiya

Working sense • What folly—to trust your promise; all night I waited as though for Judgement Day.

Four-pass portrait

Speech • Which word makes this sound like this poet rather than a generic lover?

Tension • Name the contradiction the sher refuses to solve.

Scale • Where does the poem move—from body to world, intimacy to history, or wit to metaphysics?

Imitation • Write a new two-line thought using the same emotional movement but different images.

Listening cue • Hear three reciters or singers. Record what each does with pause, speed and the final pressure word.

Portrait 05 • Bahadur Shah Zafar

بہادر شاہ ظفر

1775–1862 • exile, impermanence and late sorrow

Signature voice • The last Mughal emperor's poetic voice is read through historical loss, yet its power comes from reducing empire to intimate human need.

Recognition cluster • vatan • qafas • umr • nishaan

A signature sher

عمر دراز مانگ کے لائے تھے چار دن
دو آرزو میں کٹ گئے دو انتظار میں

umr-e-daraaz maang ke laaye the chaar din / do aarzu mein kat gaye, do intezaar mein

Working sense • I obtained four days of long life: two passed in longing and two in waiting.

Four-pass portrait

Speech • Which word makes this sound like this poet rather than a generic lover?

Tension • Name the contradiction the sher refuses to solve.

Scale • Where does the poem move—from body to world, intimacy to history, or wit to metaphysics?

Imitation • Write a new two-line thought using the same emotional movement but different images.

Listening cue • Hear three reciters or singers. Record what each does with pause, speed and the final pressure word.

Portrait 06 • Allama Iqbal

علامہ اقبال

1877–1938 • *selfhood, ascent and awakening*

Signature voice • Iqbal converts the inherited language of love into disciplined agency, ethical becoming and civilisational renewal.

Recognition cluster • khudi • parwaaz • shaheen • amal

A signature sher

ستاروں سے آگے جہاں اور بھی ہیں
ابھی عشق کے امتحاں اور بھی ہیں

sitaaron se aage jahaan aur bhi hain / abhi ishq ke imtihaan aur bhi hain

Working sense • Beyond the stars are other worlds; more trials of love still remain.

Four-pass portrait

Speech • Which word makes this sound like this poet rather than a generic lover?

Tension • Name the contradiction the sher refuses to solve.

Scale • Where does the poem move—from body to world, intimacy to history, or wit to metaphysics?

Imitation • Write a new two-line thought using the same emotional movement but different images.

Listening cue • Hear three reciters or singers. Record what each does with pause, speed and the final pressure word.

Portrait 07 • Hasrat Mohani

حسرت موہانی

1875–1951 • romance joined to freedom

Signature voice • Hasrat's lyrical intimacy coexists with political commitment; tenderness and rebellion need not occupy separate lives.

Recognition cluster • ishq • inquilaab • yaad • siyasat

A signature sher

چپکے چپکے رات دن آنسو بہانا یاد ہے
ہم کو اب تک عاشقی کا وہ زمانہ یاد ہے

chupke chupke raat din aansu bahaana yaad hai / hum ko ab tak aashiqi ka woh zamaana yaad hai

Working sense • I remember quietly shedding tears night and day; I still remember that season of love.

Four-pass portrait

Speech • Which word makes this sound like this poet rather than a generic lover?

Tension • Name the contradiction the sher refuses to solve.

Scale • Where does the poem move—from body to world, intimacy to history, or wit to metaphysics?

Imitation • Write a new two-line thought using the same emotional movement but different images.

Listening cue • Hear three reciters or singers. Record what each does with pause, speed and the final pressure word.

Portrait 08 • Faiz Ahmed Faiz

فیض احمد فیض

1911–1984 • private love widened into public conscience

Signature voice • Faiz lets beloved, homeland and human freedom illuminate one another. Beauty remains sensuous even when history enters the poem.

Recognition cluster • subh • zanjeer • mehboob • insaaf

A signature sher

دل نا امید تو نہیں ناکام ہی تو ہے
لمبی ہے غم کی شام مگر شام ہی تو ہے

dil na-umeed to nahin, nakaam hi to hai / lambi hai gham ki shaam magar shaam hi to hai

Working sense • The heart is not without hope, only unsuccessful; sorrow's evening is long, but it is only an evening.

Four-pass portrait

Speech • Which word makes this sound like this poet rather than a generic lover?

Tension • Name the contradiction the sher refuses to solve.

Scale • Where does the poem move—from body to world, intimacy to history, or wit to metaphysics?

Imitation • Write a new two-line thought using the same emotional movement but different images.

Listening cue • Hear three reciters or singers. Record what each does with pause, speed and the final pressure word.

Voice-Recognition Laboratories

Meer ↔ Ghalib • Both can speak from ruin. Meer lets ruin become atmosphere; Ghalib makes it an argument that watches itself.

Momin ↔ Dagh • Both sound intimate. Momin suspends presence in uncertainty; Dagh stages the social intelligence of promise and complaint.

Zafar ↔ Hasrat • Both remember lost time. Zafar compresses life toward extinction; Hasrat revives an entire emotional season through recollection.

Iqbal ↔ Faiz • Both widen poetry toward collective life. Iqbal often commands ascent; Faiz preserves tenderness while exposing historical constraint.

Blind-reading protocol

Cover the name • Read aloud before seeking biographical clues.

Circle glue words • The smallest connectors often reveal intellectual movement.

Name the posture • Is the voice lamenting, teasing, commanding, remembering or witnessing?

Offer two candidates • State evidence for each; then identify the decisive fingerprint.

Verify • Treat remembered attribution as a claim to check, never as proof.

Crossing the Threshold into Qawwali

لفظ سے آواز، آواز سے حال

From word to voice; from voice to spiritual state.

Qawwali is not simply Urdu poetry set to fast handclaps. It is a South Asian Sufi performance tradition in which Arabic, Persian, Urdu, Hindavi, Punjabi and other languages may coexist. A text is selected, framed, repeated, expanded and answered so that intellectual meaning can become embodied attention.

Three layers • Text gives semantic possibility; musical procedure gives time and intensity; the gathering gives response and shared presence.

Poem • The written lines, with their inherited imagery and grammar.

Performance text • The actual sequence: invocations, refrains, repeated words, inserted verses and improvisations.

Event • A particular place, lineage, audience, intention and spiritual etiquette.

Recording • A fixed trace of an event—valuable, but not identical with the living gathering.

How a Qawwali Performance Builds Meaning

1 • Establish • Instrumental or vocal preparation creates tonal ground and collective attention.

2 • Invoke • Sacred praise or an opening formula locates the gathering within remembrance.

3 • State • The lead presents a line clearly enough for language and melody to settle.

4 • Answer • The party repeats or responds; private utterance becomes social fact.

5 • Expand • A word, hemistich or refrain is reiterated; related verses may be inserted.

6 • Intensify • Tempo, clapping, melodic height and vocal exchange increase pressure.

7 • Dwell • Time may appear to stop inside one name, image or syllable.

8 • Resolve • Cadence, prayer, rang or a return to the refrain closes without exhausting meaning.

A crucial distinction • Repetition does not merely emphasise a pre-existing meaning. It changes the listener's relation to the word—statement can become question, memory, plea, certainty or surrender.

Thirty-Six Words for Entering the Mehfil

ROMAN	URDU	WORKING RANGE
sama'	سماع	spiritual audition; attentive sacred listening
qawl	قول	saying; utterance; an early performance category
qaul	قول	common South Asian spelling/pronunciation of qawl
hamd	حمد	praise of God
na't	نعت	praise of the Prophet
manqabat	منقبت	praise of a saint or sacred figure
munajaat	مناجات	intimate supplication
marsiya	مرثیہ	lament or elegy
zikr	ذکر	remembrance; repeated invocation
haal	حال	spiritual state; present condition
wajd	وجد	ecstatic finding or transport
kaif	کیف	rapture; felt intoxication

Qawwali Lexicon • Continued

ROMAN	URDU	WORKING RANGE
nisbat	نسبت	spiritual connection or affiliation
faiz	فیض	grace; beneficent spiritual flow
murshid	مرشد	spiritual guide
pir	پیر	elder; Sufi guide
faqir	فقیر	spiritual poor one; dervish
darvesh	درویش	dervish; renunciant seeker
dargah	درگاہ	saint's shrine; threshold of presence
aastaan	آستان	threshold; revered court
mehfil	محفل	gathering or assembly
mahbub	محبوب	beloved; sometimes divinely layered
ishq-e-haqiqi	عشقِ حقیقی	love of ultimate Reality
ishq-e-majazi	عشقِ مجازی	human or metaphorical love

Qawwali Lexicon • Continued

ROMAN	URDU	WORKING RANGE
fana	فنا	annihilation of separate selfhood
baqa	بقا	abiding in or through the Divine
tauhid	توحید	divine unity
hijr	ہجر	separation
visaal	وصال	union; meeting
rang	رنگ	colour; spiritual colouring
mast	مست	rapturously intoxicated
saqi	ساقی	cupbearer; giver of spiritual wine
maikada	مے کدہ	tavern; heterodox spiritual space
jaam	جام	cup
nazar	نظر	gaze; grace-conferring attention
karam	کرم	generosity; grace

Twelve Guided Qawwali Encounters

These are reading and listening gateways, not definitive performance scripts. Qawwali texts circulate in multiple versions; traditional attributions and spellings can vary across lineages and recordings. Use the language closely while allowing the living tradition its plurality.

Listening sequence • First hear without transcript. Then follow the refrain. Only on the third pass parse every word.

Encounter 01 • Hamd • praise before petition

اللہ ہی اللہ کیا کرو

allah hi allah kiya karo

Working sense • Let the Divine Name become the centre of utterance.

Performance movement • Repetition here is not empty duplication: each return can deepen breath, attention and collective alignment.

Listen with five ears

Text • Underline the word whose dictionary meaning is insufficient.

Lead • How does the solo voice introduce or reshape the line?

Response • What does the answering chorus make communal?

Time • Where does repetition suspend forward movement?

Meaning • Mark how a lead phrase becomes a shared response. What changes when meaning is carried by the room?

Notebook line • Write one sentence beginning: 'After the fifth repetition, this word no longer meant only...'

Encounter 02 • Qaul • the authority of transmitted saying

من کنت مولاه فهذا علی مولاه

man kuntu maulaahu fa-haaza Aliyyun maulaahu

Working sense • Whoever has me as master, has Ali as master.

Performance movement • In qawwali practice, Arabic declaration, rhythmic reiteration and praise meet. Attend to maula: patron, master, guardian and beloved resonance cannot be reduced to one English word.

Listen with five ears

Text • Underline the word whose dictionary meaning is insufficient.

Lead • How does the solo voice introduce or reshape the line?

Response • What does the answering chorus make communal?

Time • Where does repetition suspend forward movement?

Meaning • Listen for the point at which semantic statement becomes rhythmic invocation.

Notebook line • Write one sentence beginning: 'After the fifth repetition, this word no longer meant only...'

Encounter 03 • Na't • praise as longing

بلغ العلى بكماله
كشف الدجى بجماله

balaghal-ula bi-kamaalihi / kashafad-duja bi-jamaalihi

Working sense • By his perfection he reached the heights; by his beauty he dispelled darkness.

Performance movement • Balanced syntax makes praise memorable. Height/light and perfection/beauty operate as paired fields rather than as isolated compliments.

Listen with five ears

Text • Underline the word whose dictionary meaning is insufficient.

Lead • How does the solo voice introduce or reshape the line?

Response • What does the answering chorus make communal?

Time • Where does repetition suspend forward movement?

Meaning • Recite the two halves with equal breath. Which parallel sounds bind them?

Notebook line • Write one sentence beginning: 'After the fifth repetition, this word no longer meant only...'

Encounter 04 • Manqabat • praise and allegiance

علی مولا علی مولا

Ali maula, Ali maula

Working sense • Ali, master and protecting friend.

Performance movement • A small phrase accumulates history, affection and affiliation through return. The performer may extend maula until its vowel becomes emotional space.

Listen with five ears

Text • Underline the word whose dictionary meaning is insufficient.

Lead • How does the solo voice introduce or reshape the line?

Response • What does the answering chorus make communal?

Time • Where does repetition suspend forward movement?

Meaning • Track three repetitions: statement, intensification, surrender.

Notebook line • Write one sentence beginning: 'After the fifth repetition, this word no longer meant only...'

Encounter 05 • Amir Khusrau tradition • colour

آج رنگ ہے اے ماں رنگ ہے ری
میرے محبوب کے گھر رنگ ہے ری

aaj rang hai ai maan rang hai ri / mere mahboob ke ghar rang hai ri

Working sense • Today there is colour, mother—colour in my beloved's house.

Performance movement • Domestic Hindavi speech carries initiatory joy. Rang is colour, celebration and transformation by the guide's presence.

Listen with five ears

Text • Underline the word whose dictionary meaning is insufficient.

Lead • How does the solo voice introduce or reshape the line?

Response • What does the answering chorus make communal?

Time • Where does repetition suspend forward movement?

Meaning • Who is the mother being addressed, and why does private joy need a witness?

Notebook line • Write one sentence beginning: 'After the fifth repetition, this word no longer meant only...'

Encounter 06 • Amir Khusrau tradition • the stolen self

چھاپ تلک سب چھینی رے موسے نیناں ملائیکے

chhaap tilak sab chheeni re mose naina milaike

Working sense • You took away my mark and identity merely by meeting my eyes.

Performance movement • Ornament, social identity and ego are removed through the gaze. The line can be heard as romance, discipleship and annihilation at once.

Listen with five ears

Text • Underline the word whose dictionary meaning is insufficient.

Lead • How does the solo voice introduce or reshape the line?

Response • What does the answering chorus make communal?

Time • Where does repetition suspend forward movement?

Meaning • Separate chhaap, tilak, naina and chheeni; then rebuild their symbolic chain.

Notebook line • Write one sentence beginning: 'After the fifth repetition, this word no longer meant only...'

Encounter 07 • Persian–Hindavi bridge

زحالِ مسکین مکن تغافل
درائے نیناں بنائے بتیاں

zehaal-e miskeen makun taghaaful / duraaye naina banaaye batiyaan

Working sense • Do not neglect this poor one's state, turning away your eyes and inventing talk.

Performance movement • The celebrated macaronic texture moves between Persian and Hindavi within one utterance. Linguistic crossing enacts a lover divided between courtly refinement and intimate complaint.

Listen with five ears

Text • Underline the word whose dictionary meaning is insufficient.

Lead • How does the solo voice introduce or reshape the line?

Response • What does the answering chorus make communal?

Time • Where does repetition suspend forward movement?

Meaning • Hear where the language changes. Does the emotion change with it?

Notebook line • Write one sentence beginning: 'After the fifth repetition, this word no longer meant only...'

Encounter 08 • Bulleh Shah in the qawwali world

بلھیا کی جاناں میں کون

Bulleya ki jaana main kaun

Working sense • Bulleh, how could I know who I am?

Performance movement • Punjabi, not Urdu, yet central to the wider qawwali repertoire. Its negations dismantle fixed religious, social and personal labels.

Listen with five ears

Text • Underline the word whose dictionary meaning is insufficient.

Lead • How does the solo voice introduce or reshape the line?

Response • What does the answering chorus make communal?

Time • Where does repetition suspend forward movement?

Meaning • List the identities a performance negates; ask whether the refrain ends in emptiness or freedom.

Notebook line • Write one sentence beginning: 'After the fifth repetition, this word no longer meant only...'

Encounter 09 • Kabir in shared performance culture

من لاگو یار فقیری میں

man laago yaar faqiri mein

Working sense • My heart is attached, friend, to the life of spiritual poverty.

Performance movement • The vernacular voice makes faqiri desirable rather than deprived. Yaar allows friendly, human and divine address to overlap.

Listen with five ears

Text • Underline the word whose dictionary meaning is insufficient.

Lead • How does the solo voice introduce or reshape the line?

Response • What does the answering chorus make communal?

Time • Where does repetition suspend forward movement?

Meaning • What values reverse when poverty becomes wealth?

Notebook line • Write one sentence beginning: 'After the fifth repetition, this word no longer meant only...'

Encounter 10 • Ghazal entering qawwali

خبر تحیر عشق سن نہ جنوں رہا نہ پری رہی

khabar-e tahayyur-e ishq sun, na junoon raha na pari rahi

Working sense • Hear the news of love's bewilderment: neither madness nor the fairy-beloved remained as before.

Performance movement • In performance, a literary ghazal may be opened by repetition, inserted couplets and melodic expansion. Syntax becomes experience before it becomes explanation.

Listen with five ears

Text • Underline the word whose dictionary meaning is insufficient.

Lead • How does the solo voice introduce or reshape the line?

Response • What does the answering chorus make communal?

Time • Where does repetition suspend forward movement?

Meaning • First follow only the radif-like returns; on a second listening, reconstruct the sentence.

Notebook line • Write one sentence beginning: 'After the fifth repetition, this word no longer meant only...'

Encounter 11 • Munajaat • intimate need

کرم کی اک نظر ہم پر خدا را

karam ki ek nazar hum par, khudaara

Working sense • For God's sake, cast one gracious glance upon us.

Performance movement • Nazar is both seeing and transformative attention. Petition becomes collective through hum, allowing every listener to enter the line.

Listen with five ears

Text • Underline the word whose dictionary meaning is insufficient.

Lead • How does the solo voice introduce or reshape the line?

Response • What does the answering chorus make communal?

Time • Where does repetition suspend forward movement?

Meaning • How would the emotional force change if hum became main?

Notebook line • Write one sentence beginning: 'After the fifth repetition, this word no longer meant only...'

Encounter 12 • Rang as closure and renewal

سدا رنگ رہے میرے خواجہ کے گھر

sada rang rahe mere khwaaja ke ghar

Working sense • May colour forever remain in my master's house.

Performance movement • A rang may close a shrine-oriented gathering while reopening belonging. The wish is not merely for spectacle but for enduring spiritual vitality.

Listen with five ears

Text • Underline the word whose dictionary meaning is insufficient.

Lead • How does the solo voice introduce or reshape the line?

Response • What does the answering chorus make communal?

Time • Where does repetition suspend forward movement?

Meaning • Notice how sada changes today's colour into continuity.

Notebook line • Write one sentence beginning: 'After the fifth repetition, this word no longer meant only...'

The Qawwali Listening Notebook

Identity • Title or opening words; performer; venue/album; approximate duration.

Languages • Mark each shift among Arabic, Persian, Urdu, Hindavi, Punjabi or another language.

Text spine • Write only the lines that organise the whole performance.

Inserted poetry • Note any extra sher, doha or verse and how it comments on the spine.

Refrain map • Count returns; mark who leads and who answers.

Intensity curve • Use five stages from quiet establishment to peak and resolution.

Pressure word • Which single word receives the greatest melodic or rhythmic dwelling?

Interpretive change • What did performance reveal that silent reading did not?

Ethical note • Distinguish informed interpretation from claims about another person's spiritual state.

One Recording, Three Passes

Pass 1 • Receive • No transcript. Notice bodily rhythm, return, contrast and emotional trajectory.

Pass 2 • Follow • Use the text. Mark every point where performed order differs from written order.

Pass 3 • Interpret • Ask how repetition, inserted verse and audience response alter the semantic centre.

After 24 hours • Recite the core lines without music. What remains in memory: argument, image, tune or name?

Comparative exercise • Hear two performances of the same textual spine. Compare architecture rather than declaring a winner: opening, diction, interpolation, tempo, climax and closure.

A Ten-Week Poet-and-Qawwali Apprenticeship

WEEK	FOCUS	CORE WORK	OUTPUT
1	Meer + Ghalib	Two recitations each	Contrast atmosphere with argument.
2	Momin + Dagħ	Pronoun and dialogue map	Hear intimacy and social speech.
3	Zafar + Hasrat	Memory notebook	Compare extinction with recollection.
4	Iqbal + Faiz	Scale map	Track self, society and history.
5	Qawwali threshold	Lexicon 1–18	Identify form, guide, state and space.
6	Qawwali lexicon	Lexicon 19–36	Map love, annihilation and grace.
7	Encounters 1–4	Praise sequence	Hamd, qaul, na’t and manqabat.
8	Encounters 5–8	Language-crossing map	Rang, gaze, Persian–Hindavi, Punjabi.
9	Encounters 9–12	Refrain analysis	Faqiri, ghazal, petition and closure.
10	Comparative mehfil	Two full recordings	Submit a 600-word listening essay.

The Volume 8 Completion Test

شعر کو پہچانو، آواز کو سنو، حال کا احترام کرو

Recognise the poem, hear the voice, respect the state.

Poet fingerprint • Can you propose a poet from address, hinge, image climate, scale and posture?

Evidence • Can you distinguish recognition from verified attribution?

Qawwali forms • Can you explain hamd, na't, manqabat, munajaat, qaul and rang?

Vocabulary • Can you use at least twenty-five qawwali terms without flattening them?

Performance text • Can you separate the written poem from the order actually sung?

Repetition • Can you describe how a word changes across returns?

Language plurality • Can you hear language shifts without calling every vernacular line Urdu?

Listening essay • Can you compare two performances through architecture, not celebrity or speed?

Series milestone • You can now move between page and performance: recognise poetic temperaments, read the semantic spine of a qawwali, and listen for how a gathering turns inherited language into renewed experience.

Bridge to Volume 9

The next volume can become a full listening companion: ghazal singing, tarannum, qawwali, film poetry and modern spoken verse—with curated pathways, pronunciation drills, transcript annotation and comparative performance studies.